WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

BELGIUM

Europe

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Brussels-Capital Region	Seat of the main EU institutions and NATO, and the federal government; a natural base for EU affairs, regional headquarters and professional services, supported by hub.brussels	EU and public affairs, finance, professional services, digital
Antwerp	Home to Port of Antwerp-Bruges, which handled 266.5 million tonnes in 2025, and a major petrochemical cluster	Chemicals, logistics, energy transition, trade
Zeebrugge (Bruges)	Coastal part of the merged Port of Antwerp-Bruges, specialising in roll-on/roll-off traffic and energy	Automotive logistics, LNG, offshore wind
Ghent	Inland seaport and industrial city with a strong university and biotech base	Steel and manufacturing, life sciences, logistics
Leuven and the Flemish Brabant corridor	University city at the centre of Flanders' research and technology ecosystem	Semiconductors, life sciences, deep tech
Walloon Brabant and Liège	Wallonia's biotech and logistics hubs; Wallonia attracted €1.3 billion of foreign investment in 2025, up 34%	Biopharmaceuticals, air cargo and logistics, advanced manufacturing
Charleroi and Hainaut	Southern industrial region with available land and links to France	Biotech manufacturing, aerospace, logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Regional investment agencies handle foreign investment: Flanders Investment & Trade (FIT), hub.brussels and the Wallonia Export and Investment Agency (AWEX), each offering site selection, incentives guidance and aftercare
- A 25% corporate income tax, with an innovation income deduction of 85% of net innovation income, giving an effective rate of 3.75% on qualifying income
- An 80% partial exemption from wage withholding tax for qualifying R&D staff, and a reformed investment deduction including a 40% targeted track for SMEs
- An improved expatriate tax regime from 2026, with the tax-free allowance raised to 35% of gross salary and a lower minimum salary of €70,000
- Euro-area membership: the euro is the national currency, with free movement of capital and no exchange controls

- EU single-market and Schengen membership as a founding member of the EU, giving free movement of goods, services, capital and people
- Port of Antwerp-Bruges and inland waterway, rail and road links offering access to the EU's core industrial markets

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Belgium in November 2026 offers investors a highly open, productive economy at the heart of the EU, with direct access to the EU institutions, one of Europe's largest ports and a strong research and life-sciences base. GDP grew 1.0% in 2025 and accelerated to 0.3% quarter-on-quarter in the third quarter of 2026, the fastest pace since early 2025, led by services. Foreign investment remains robust: Flanders attracted 285 foreign projects worth €3.79 billion in 2025, creating 5,870 jobs, with the United States the largest investor, while Wallonia drew €1.3 billion, up 34%, and its exports reached a record €62.4 billion. Generous innovation incentives, including an effective 3.75% tax rate on qualifying innovation income, and the unlimited carry-forward of the investment deduction from 2026 add to the appeal.

Belgium's main structural challenge is restoring public finances while managing high energy costs. The European Commission projects a deficit of 5.2% of GDP in 2025 and 2026 and debt rising from 107.9% to 110.5% of GDP, and Belgium is under an EU excessive deficit procedure. Inflation reached 5.26% in October 2026, driven by energy prices, and in early November Prime Minister Bart De Wever offered his government's resignation after coalition talks on about €10 billion of savings by 2029 failed. Belgium's fundamentals nonetheless remain strong: high productivity, a skilled multilingual workforce, deep trade links and wage indexation that supports demand. A credible budget agreement would strengthen the outlook, while energy-transition, port, defence and life-sciences projects continue to create opportunities.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Public finances and political uncertainty	Deficits of about 5% of GDP and debt above 100% of GDP are under an EU procedure, and the government offered its resignation in November 2026 over a budget deadlock	Belgium's institutions and EU framework provide continuity; monitor the budget outcome and possible tax changes, including on capital gains
Energy prices and inflation	Inflation reached 5.26% in October 2026, with energy prices up 33%, raising input costs	Use long-term energy contracts, efficiency investment and on-site renewables, and model inflation scenarios
Labour costs and automatic wage indexation	Wages are automatically indexed to inflation, pushing up labour costs when prices rise	Offset with R&D wage withholding exemptions, productivity investment and the expatriate regime
Russian assets held at Euroclear	Around €210 billion of Russian central bank assets are immobilised in Europe, mostly at Brussels-based Euroclear, and Russia's central bank has sued Euroclear in Moscow	Financial-sector investors should take sanctions and litigation advice; EU sanctions apply to all Russia-linked dealings
Complex federal structure	Responsibilities are split between the federal state, regions and communities, so permits and incentives vary by region	Engage the relevant regional agency early and use specialist local advisers
Permitting and land availability	Environmental permits and land for large industrial projects can take time, especially near ports	Use established port and industrial zones and plan permit timelines carefully
Tax policy changes	Pending measures include a new capital gains tax of up to 10% and conditions on the reduced SME rate	Model scenarios with tax advisers and monitor parliamentary approval

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Belgium's risk profile is that of a wealthy founding member of the EU and the euro area, with strong legal certainty, an open economy and a central role in European institutions. The near-term issues are fiscal and political: debt above 100% of GDP and deficits of about 5% are under an EU excessive deficit procedure, and on 2 November 2026 Prime Minister Bart De Wever offered the resignation of his five-party coalition after budget talks failed, with the King holding it under consideration and consulting party leaders. Belgium has a long record of maintaining stable administration through government transitions, and EU fiscal rules anchor consolidation. Inflation of 5.26% in October 2026 reflects energy prices, and ECB policy, with the deposit rate at 2.5%, is directed at containing it. Investors in finance should note that most immobilised Russian central bank assets are held at Euroclear in Brussels; EU sanctions apply to all Russia-related dealings and specialist advice is recommended.

MARKET ACCESS

As a founding member of the EU and the euro area, Belgium gives investors tariff-free access to the EU single market and all of the EU's free trade agreements, with WTO membership and the EU's common trade policy governing trade with third countries. Its location between France, Germany, the Netherlands and the UK places much of the EU's purchasing power within easy reach. Port of Antwerp-Bruges handled 266.5 million tonnes in 2025, with container volumes stable, and is connected to the European hinterland by inland waterways, rail and motorways. Brussels hosts the main EU institutions and NATO, making Belgium the natural centre for EU regulatory engagement.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Bart De Wever)	Leads the five-party federal coalition, which offered its resignation in November 2026 over the multi-year budget	Primary reference point for federal economic, fiscal and tax policy
Regional investment agencies (FIT, hub.brussels, AWEX)	Lead foreign investment promotion and incentives in Flanders, Brussels and Wallonia respectively	Standard first points of contact for market entry, sites and grants
National Bank of Belgium	National central bank within the Eurosystem; its governor sits on the ECB Governing Council, and it supervises banks and insurers	Relevant for banking, payments and financial-sector authorisations
Federal Public Service Finance	Administers federal taxes, including innovation and investment deductions and rulings	Key counterpart for tax rulings and incentives
Port of Antwerp-Bruges	Publicly owned port authority managing one of Europe's leading ports and chemical clusters	Partner for logistics, energy-transition and industrial-site investment
Euroclear	Brussels-based international securities depository holding most immobilised Russian central bank assets	Relevant for capital-markets activity and sanctions-related risk assessment
European Union institutions in Brussels	The Commission, Council and Parliament set the regulatory framework for the single market	Essential for regulatory engagement and EU funding programmes

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Federation of Enterprises in Belgium (FEB/VBO), the regional employers' bodies VOKA in Flanders and the Union Wallonne des Entreprises, and the American Chamber of Commerce in Belgium are the main business associations. FIT, hub.brussels and AWEX run investor events and international missions, and sector clusters support partnerships in chemicals, life sciences and logistics. The European Investment Bank, headquartered in neighbouring Luxembourg, and EU programmes provide co-financing for qualifying projects. Brussels' concentration of EU institutions, NATO, trade associations and embassies gives investors unmatched access to policy networks and events.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Belgium suits investors seeking a central, high-skill base inside the EU and the euro area: life-sciences, biotech and research-intensive companies using the innovation income deduction and R&D wage incentives; chemicals, energy-transition and logistics investors around Port of Antwerp-Bruges and Ghent; companies establishing EU headquarters or regulatory-affairs teams in Brussels; and defence and technology firms serving rising European defence budgets. Financial-sector investors should take sanctions advice on Russia-related exposures.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the relevant regional investment agency
Contact FIT, hub.brussels or AWEX according to location to compare sites, regional grants and permit routes.

STEP 2: Structure for innovation and R&D incentives
Assess eligibility for the innovation income deduction, R&D wage withholding exemption and investment deduction with tax advisers.

STEP 3: Shortlist port, industrial and research locations
Compare Port of Antwerp-Bruges, Ghent, Leuven and Walloon sites according to logistics, energy and talent needs.

STEP 4: Monitor the federal budget and tax measures
Track the outcome of the government crisis, the multi-year budget and pending capital gains and SME tax changes.

STEP 5: Plan for energy, wage and sanctions considerations
Build energy-price and wage-indexation scenarios into models and screen any Russia-related counterparts under EU sanctions.